PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #69 · ABUSE

“I don’t get to decide what happens to my body. Saying no doesn’t count.”

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Where it often comes from

When someone treats your body as if it belonged to them, you can start to believe the treatment. “I don’t get to decide. Saying no doesn’t count.” That is what harm teaches. It is not the truth. Your body is not a possession of another person. A no counts even if it was ignored. A yes that was forced, frightened, or not free was not a real yes. You do not have to describe what happened in order to hold this truth. A counselor can help you practice choice in ordinary, safe ways. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

You are fearfully and wonderfully made. That is not a slogan for people who were never harmed. It means your body is not trash and not someone else’s property. When you pass through what feels like deep water, God is with you. He is near the brokenhearted. He cares for you. Nothing can separate you from His love. These verses do not erase what was done. They say your no still counts, and your body is still yours to steward before God, not to surrender to whoever demands it.

> *“I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well”* (Psalm 139:14).

Also see

> “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze” (Isaiah 43:2).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you” (1 Peter 5:7).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

Common self-statements

- I do not get a vote about my own body.
- Saying no just makes it worse, so it does not count.
- If I froze, I agreed.
- My body is already ruined, so boundaries are pointless.
- Other people’s wants matter more than my no.
- God expects me to submit even when I am afraid.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: If your no was ignored once, it never counts.

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling powerless and concluding you have no right to choose.
- Personalization: Treating their demand as a duty you failed by refusing.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring every choice you do have now.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that my no does not count?
- What is one choice about my body or my time that is actually mine today?
- Would I tell a friend their no was meaningless?
- Does freezing or fear turn a no into a yes?
- What does “fearfully and wonderfully made” deny about being owned?
- What small boundary can I practice with a safe person or my counselor?

Truth summary

> My body is not someone else’s to decide about. My no counts, even if it was ignored.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

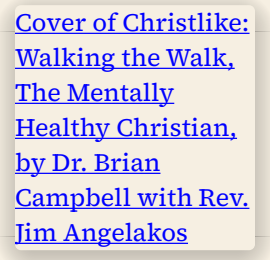
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Fear
- Love, By God
- Guilt/Shame
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering
- Love

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
The lie that your no does not count is not the truth about your body.

Greater — MercyMe
God's care for you is greater than someone else's claim on your body.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
What you want for your own body is allowed to matter.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
Christ is gentle. Gentleness does not override your no.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I don't get to decide what happens to my body. Saying no doesn't count."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I don't get to decide what happens to my body. Saying no doesn't count." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me that my no does not count?
- ☐ What is one choice about my body or my time that is actually mine today?
- ☐ Would I tell a friend their no was meaningless?
- ☐ Does freezing or fear turn a no into a yes?
- ☐ What does "fearfully and wonderfully made" deny about being owned?
- ☐ What small boundary can I practice with a safe person or my counselor?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My body is not someone else's to decide about. My no counts, even if it was ignored.
- ☐ A no counts even when someone acts as if it does not.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made, not owned.
- ☐ Forced or frightened agreement is not a real yes.
- ☐ I can practice small choices now.
- ☐ God is near me. He does not side with the person who ignored my no.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ Isaiah 43:2
  "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When your no felt like it did not count: Each day, write down one moment when a choice about your body felt impossible. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 139:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made. My no counts.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.

- [ ] Practice one small no with a safe person, about time, touch, or a favor. You do not have to explain.
- [ ] Write "my no counts" where you will see it. Do not add the story underneath.
- [ ] Tell your counselor that choice about your body feels gone. Ask for ordinary ways to practice it. Stop if you need to.
- [ ] If someone is overriding your no now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233. You do not have to manage that alone.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I don't get to decide what happens to my body. Saying no doesn't count.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A no I was allowed to mean
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I don't get to decide what happens to my body.~~

~~Saying no doesn't count~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I was taught that my body was not mine to decide about. I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Restore the truth that my no counts, and give me safe help as I learn to choose again. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.